

with less than a year to go for the Paris Olympics.

A perfect protagonist. An inspiring narrative. But what's a good story without an equally good redemption arc?

Almost as spectacularly as she rose, Sift took a fall. Expectations were high ahead of the Summer Games. In fact, she was touted to outshine poster girl Manu Bhaker. "It is only in India that the Olympics is hyped up so much. There is publicity even before the competition. It was all very new for me. When people started talking while it was all building up to the day, a bit of nerves had crept in," Sift admits.

But, in the end, Sift finished 31st in a field of 32 to return empty-handed. She, her coach Deepali Deshpande, and even the odd fan scrolling through the online scoreboard were understandably

stunned into silence.

Sift's mother Ramnik Kaur, who was seated in the stands, had the most unexpected reaction of all. "My mom poked fun, saying you came second but from the bottom. This was right after I had packed. She was just trying to make me laugh," Sift remembers.

The gravity of the situation, though, wasn't lost on Ramnik. Knowing that Sift loved to travel, she promptly packed bags to get her daughter to shift her attention away from what had just transpired.

"Nobody allowed me to stay alone during that period because they figured that wouldn't be the right thing to do," Sift says.

"My parents asked me to pack my stuff. My cousin had come down and we went on a mini one-day trip. My mother kept saying, 'It was just a bad day, let it go.' Yes, the Olympics comes once every four years, but for a professional athlete, it is just another tournament where, unfortunately, I didn't fare that well. It wasn't like I was going to stop shooting after that. I was sulking a bit, but only

because I knew people were expecting a lot from me. The bad aftertaste lingered until I came to India."

Back home, Sift's father, Pawandeep Singh, took charge. "The day after I landed, Dad sent me to the range to prepare for 10m air rifle for the upcoming State competition. My father never gave me the liberty of having an idle mind so that I didn't end up overthinking. Some people said I should have rested. I do understand where they came from, but I feel it was also important to get it ingrained in my head that all was normal and nothing out of the ordinary had just happened."

But how does one shake off an Olympic disappointment? It would seem Sift would have had to spend days in quiet introspection. But the reality, as it turns out, was very different.

"I had heard a lot of stories in the past. When people came back without a medal, they took time to recover. But then I thought: 'What is the point of sitting and thinking about something I cannot go back and change?'"



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SIFT SHOT 52.3 AND 51.2 IN THE FIRST TWO SERIES IN THE STANDING SEGMENT, WHICH PROPELLED HER TO THE VERY TOP OF THE LEADERBOARD